

MIRACLES AND FORBIDDEN MAGIC

ancient Hebrew magic



▲ Heaven-sent insight

In this manuscript illumination the prophet Ezekiel is flanked by an angel and, at the top right, the hand of God, the two sources of inspiration for his far-seeing powers.

There are many references to the supernatural in the Tanakh (Hebrew Bible). Although priests of the Jewish religion sanction most of these allusions, nods to earlier beliefs and ritual practices are also included, which are regarded as forbidden magic in Judaism.

Power and prophets

The conventional attitude to magic in the Tanakh is driven by the fact that the Jewish

people believe exclusively in one God. In early Judaism, religious practices that were associated with other belief systems risked being labeled as demonic. Yet magical elements of ancient Canaanite beliefs still fused with the religion in its infancy. For example, the Tanakh narrates how the prophets, who played a key role in revealing God's word, fell into ecstatic trances in order to receive their visions. One of them, Elijah, engaged in a

competition with the overtly pagan priests of Baal on a mountaintop to see who could produce fire to burn a sacrificial offering. The text also recounts how Elijah's prayers were answered and rain fell to end a prolonged drought that had blighted the land of Israel. The biblical patriarchs themselves performed miracles, acting as instruments of God's power: during the captivity of Israelites in Egypt, Moses' brother Aaron engaged in a duel with the pharaoh's magicians, who transformed their staffs into serpents, only to have Aaron change his own rod into a larger snake that devoured them all.

Telling the future

In Deuteronomy 18:10–11, Moses says: "There shall not be found among you any one that maketh his son or his daughter to pass through the fire, or that useth divination, or an observer of times, or an enchanter, or a witch, or a charmer, or a consulter with familiar spirits, or a wizard, or a necromancer." Despite these prohibitions (and there are several other passages in the Tanakh forbidding the practice of magic), prophecy was an authorized way of revealing the future. References to telling the

IN CONTEXT

The Witch of Endor

According to the Tanakh, even the Israelites' leaders sometimes resorted to dark magic, albeit with dire consequences. When King Saul was faced with an invasion by the Philistines, he consulted the temple oracle, but to no avail. In desperation, he traveled to Endor and consulted a witch, who raised the spirit of the prophet Samuel. The ghost chided Saul for disturbing him and prophesied his doom for disobeying God's commandments against such magic. A terrified Saul was defeated and died in battle the next day, his demise a terrible warning to those who flirted with necromancy.

In this 19th-century reimagining, the witch summons Samuel's spirit.

